

Session 9: The Identity of the Nephilim

Key Takeaways

- 120 years is how long it is until the flood comes. This is how long Noah will be having this dialogue with God as he builds his divinely provided refuge.
- Nephilim translates to “the fallen ones,” as in those who fall in battle. Ancient Israel’s neighbors celebrated those who won glory through conquest in battle. The Gibborim and Nephilim were heroes to the Babylonians and Canaanites, but the biblical authors see their violence as everything that is wrong with the human family.
- Genesis 6:4 is the origin story of the warrior giants the Israelites must face as they enter and occupy Canaan. These giants fill the narrative slot of the seed of the snake in the unfolding drama of the Hebrew Bible.

Did the Sons of *Elohim* Actually Have Sex With Human Women?

The plain sense meaning of this story is fairly clear: Yes, these spiritual beings crossed the Heaven and Earth boundary and had sex with women.

The phrase “and they took women for themselves” is a standard biblical Hebrew phrase for sexual intercourse, including illicit sex (see [Gen. 38:2](#); [Lev. 18:17](#), [20:17](#)).

When spiritual beings are sent on missions in the earthly realm, they are called by a functional title, *malakim* in Hebrew and in Greek, *angelos*, that is, “angels.” In the story of the Bible, angels regularly take on a human appearance and interact with humans in a physical way. They can walk with people, have meals (see [Gen. 18:1-5](#)), and wrestle with them as well (see [Gen. 32:23-32](#)).

This cosmic cross-species sexual encounter is reinforced by the presence of a narrative design pattern used by the author, who connects Genesis 6:1-4 with Genesis 3:1-7.

Genesis 2-3: The Snake and the Woman

Genesis 3:6 NASB*

And the woman saw (ראה) that the tree was good (טוב) for eating and **that (כי)** it was enticing to the eyes and it was desirable for gaining wisdom **and she took (לקח)** its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband with her and he ate.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 2:24 NASB*

Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother and cling to his wife and they will become one **flesh** (בשר).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:1-14: The Sons of God and Human Women

Genesis 6:1-2 NASB*

¹ And it came about when humanity began to multiply on the face of the land ... ² and **the sons of God saw** (ראה), the daughters of humanity (בנות האדם) **that** (כי) they **were good** (טוב), and **they took** (לקח) for themselves wives from all which they chose.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:3 NASB*

And Yahweh said, "My Spirit will not dwell with humanity forever, in as much as he also is **flesh** (בשר), and his days will be one hundred and twenty years.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The action of the sons of God is portrayed as an intensified inversion of the garden story. Instead of the woman taking what is good in her own eyes because of the deception of a spiritual being, in Genesis 6, it is rebel spiritual beings who take women who are good in their eyes.

The analogy, which is intended by the author, also prompts us to consider the motive of the sons of God in light of the woman's motive. The woman desired to have divine wisdom and life in the garden on her own terms instead of honoring the creator's command. This prompts the reader to consider the unstated motive of the sons of God in Genesis 6:1-2. If they are set on analogy with the woman, we are encouraged to see their "taking women" as a move to restore the life of Eden to humanity, in opposition to God's command to exile them from access to the tree of life.

Later in Genesis 19, we find a narrative designed on analogy with Genesis 3 and 6:1-4. In the story of Lot's hosting the two angels in Sodom, the men of Sodom come to Lot's house in order to gang rape the "men" (the angels). And Lot, in a horrifying act of betrayal, offers his daughters to the crowd of men instead of the angels. In contrast to the corrupt sons of God who take the daughters of men, here a man offers his own daughters in the place of two sons of God. In Lot's case, the angels intervene and strike all the men of Sodom with blindness. The intended analogy sets up a contrast: It shows just how corrupt humanity has become once again, presenting Lot as the opposite of Abraham and Noah.

Genesis 6:1-4

- The sons of God visit human daughters
- The sons of God have sex with them

Genesis 19

- The men of Sodom want to have sex with the sons of God who visit Sodom
- Lot offers his daughters for sex

Comparing the Sons of God with the Men of Sodom. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Genesis 6:1-4	Genesis 19
• God rescues Noah and his sons • The land is destroyed by water from the sky	• Angels rescue Lot and his daughters • The city is destroyed by fire from the sky
<i>Comparing the Sons of God with the Men of Sodom.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

How Is Genesis 6:3 a Response to the Rebellion of Spiritual Beings?

Genesis 6:3 NASB*

And Yahweh said,
 (a) “My Spirit/breath will not dwell with the human forever,
 (b) because he too is flesh,
 (c) and so his days will be one hundred and twenty years.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“My Spirit/breath will not dwell forever”

This line recalls two earlier moments in Genesis 1-3.

In Genesis 2:7, humanity is animated by God’s “breath of life.” It is only by God’s gift of life-energy that human existence is possible.

In Genesis 2:9 and 3:22, God wants humans to eat from the tree that unites them with God’s own eternal life. However, once humans have rebelled, he exiles them from access to his eternal life presence. Here in Genesis 6:3, spiritual beings have rebelled by uniting with human women, and God’s words reveal the motive: to restore eternal life to the rebellious human family! God is here saying that these illicit unions will not generate eternal life but will end in the same fate as the foolish humans in Genesis 3:22-24.

“Will not dwell (yadon) with the human”

The Hebrew word *yadon* (יָדֹן) occurs only here in ancient biblical Hebrew. There have been multiple proposals about its meaning based on Semitic languages that are related to Hebrew.

- “Judge, condemn” (related to Hebrew: *duwn* / דָּוַן) [adopted by the NIV as “contend”]
- “Strive, struggle” (NASB, KJV)

All of these proposals have been scrutinized and have no real evidence (see John Day, “The Sons of God and the Daughters of Men and the Giants,” p. 87-89)

This verb almost certainly comes from a Semitic root *danan* (דָּנַן) “to remain, abide with” (see Umberto Cassuto, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis (Part I): From Adam to Noah*, 296). This is how the earliest translators of the Hebrew Bible into Greek understood the verb.

- Septuagint *καταμείνη* / 4Q252 ידור

“Because he too is flesh”

This could be a statement about all humanity in general, but given the literary frame around Genesis 6:3 that refers to illicit sex between spiritual and human beings, this verse likely has a more specific focus.

The phrase “because he too is flesh” shows that the focus of God’s statement is creatures alongside normal humanity, that is, the children of the human and spiritual beings who have sex in Genesis 6:1-2.

In “The Episode of the Sons of God and the Daughters of Men,” Umberto Cassuto writes about how God has breathed life into humanity, but the children that will be born of these illicit unions between the sons of God and the daughters of men are not humanity in the full sense. They are mortal like their mothers, and here God declares that these children are “flesh” and so will not share in the immortal life of their fathers. Rather, they will die like all members of the human race “because they too are flesh” (Cassuto, 1973).

“His days will be one hundred and twenty years”

This statement has been interpreted in two ways.

1. It refers to a divine limit placed on the life span of humanity in general, in contrast to the long lifetimes of the patriarchs in Genesis chapter 5.

“Cutting short their lives, and making their years not so many as they formerly lived, but one hundred and twenty only.”

Josephus, Flavius. *Antiquities of the Jews*. 1.3.2.

There are a couple problems with this view. It creates a strange narrative logic. Because of the rebellious actions of a few, all humanity is “punished” with a shortened life span.

This is also strange because many people after Genesis 6 live longer than 120 years: Abraham (175 years, Gen. 25:7), Isaac (180 years, Gen. 35:28), and Jacob (147 years, Gen. 47:28), etc.

2. It refers to the number of years before the coming of the flood. This is in fact the oldest interpretation of Genesis 6:3 preserved in Jewish literature.

It is mentioned in the Dead Sea Scrolls. “In the year four hundred and eighty of Noah’s life, Noah reached the end of them. And God said: My spirit will not reside in man for ever. Their days shall be fixed at one hundred and twenty years until the end of the waters of the flood” (4Q252 1.1-3, see Devorah Dimant, “The Flood as Preamble: The Perspective of the Qumran Hebrew Texts,” pp. 110-122).

It is also mentioned in the Aramaic Targums Onkelos (“may a lengthening of time be given to them, one hundred and twenty years, that they might repent” / ארכא יהיב להון מאה ועשרין שנים אם יתובון) and Targum Neofiti (“Behold, I have given the span of one hundred and twenty years (in the hope that) perhaps they might do repentance, but they have not done so” / די יעבדון תשובה ולא עבדו). And much later, Rashi.

Genesis 6:4: Are the Nephilim the Offspring of the Sons of Elohim?

In addition to spiritual beings having sex with women, this is the next strangest part of the story.

The Rebellion of the Sons of Elohim

- a 4 **The Nephilim** were **in the land** in those days,
and also afterward,
b when **the sons of Elohim** went
c into the **daughters of humanity**
c' and they **bore children**
b' **to/for them** ;
a' **these are the mighty warriors** who are from ancient time, men of the name.

Genesis 6:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

This passage tells us that a group called the Nephilim lived in the land “in those days.” The word “Nephilim” appears only one other time in the Hebrew Bible, and it helps us understand what’s happening here in Genesis 6.

Numbers 13:32-33 NASB*

³² So [the spies] gave the sons of Israel a bad report of the land which they had spied out, saying, “The land through which we have gone, in spying it out, is a land that devours its inhabitants; and all the people whom we saw in it are **men of great size**. ³³ There also we saw **the Nephilim (the sons of Anak are from the Nephilim)**; and we became like grasshoppers in our own sight, and so we were in their sight.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Nephilim are giant warriors from ancient times. This is why the first translation of the Hebrew Bible into ancient Greek (produced around 300-100 B.C.E.) translated the Hebrew word Nephilim as γίγαντες / gigantes / giant!

The word Nephilim is not a translation but a transliteration of the Hebrew word. It is a noun derived from the Hebrew root *naphal* meaning “to fall.” It mostly likely means “fallen ones,” referring to warriors fallen in battle. The verbal form of this root is found describing fallen warriors (Gibborim, also used in Gen. 6:4) elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible.

2 Samuel 1:27 NASB*

How have the **mighty warriors** (*gibborim*) **fallen** (*naphal*), and the weapons of war perished!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 32:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ For thus says Yahweh Elohim [to Egypt], “The sword of the king of Babylon will come upon you. By the swords of the **mighty warriors** (*gibborim*) ¹² I will cause your hordes **to fall** (*naphal*); all of them are tyrants of the nations, and they will devastate the pride of Egypt, and all its hordes will be destroyed.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These giant warriors have a prominent role in the biblical stories about Israel’s entry into the land promised to Abraham. Many of the cities and kings that attacked the Israelites when they entered the land were among the offspring of these giant warriors whose origin stems back to the Nephilim.

Deuteronomy 9:1-2 NIV

¹ Hear, Israel: You are now about to cross the Jordan to go in and dispossess **nations greater and stronger than you**, with large cities that have walls up to the sky. ² **The people are strong and tall—Anakites!** You know about them and have heard it said: “Who can stand up against the Anakites?”

Deuteronomy 2:10-11 NIV

¹⁰ The **Emites** used to live there—a **people strong** and numerous, and as **tall as the Anakites**. ¹¹ Like the **Anakites**, they too were considered **Rephaim**, but the Moabites called them Emites.

Deuteronomy 3:10-11 NIV

¹⁰ We took all the towns on the plateau, and all Gilead, and all Bashan as far as Salekah and Edrei, towns of Og’s kingdom in Bashan. ¹¹ (**Og king of Bashan was the last of the Rephaim. His bed was decorated with iron and was more than nine cubits long and four cubits wide. It is still in Rabbah of the Ammonites.**)

Joshua 11:21-22 NIV

²¹ At that time Joshua went and destroyed the **Anakites** from the hill country: from Hebron, Debir and Anab, from all the hill country of Judah, and from all the hill country of Israel. Joshua totally destroyed them and their towns. ²² **No Anakites were left in Israelite territory;** only in Gaza, **Gath** and Ashdod **did any survive**.

1 Samuel 17:4 NIV

A champion named **Goliath, who was from Gath**, came out of the Philistine camp. His height was six cubits and a span.

Amos 2:9 NASB

Yet it was I who destroyed **the Amorite** before them, though **his height was like the height of cedars** and he was **strong as the oaks**; I even destroyed his fruit above and his root below.

But are these giant warriors of old the offspring of the sons of *Elohim* and the daughters of men? The text is not explicit; rather it uses poetic parallel structures to suggest this.

“The Nephilim were in the land **in those days ... when** the sons of God were going into the daughters of men and they were bearing children for them, these were the mighty warriors.”

The poetic structure of the text coordinates the two things:

1. The presence of the great, giant warriors of the ancient past

2. The sons of *Elohim* having sex with women.

The phrase “in the day, which ...” (Heb. *yom* + *’asher* / יום + אשר) is a standard way of coordinating two events as taking place at the same time (see Deut. 4:10; 1 Kgs. 22:25; Judg. 4:14; 2 Sam. 19:25; see *The Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon*, p. 82).

It’s as if the text is drawing attention to the presence of the Nephilim in the land during the time period when the sons of *Elohim* were having sex with women. Hint hint.

“Mighty Warriors”

The Hebrew word is *gibbor* (singular) and *gibborim* (plural). While this word is not inherently negative (it will be applied to Israelite warriors in Josh. 1:14 and heroes like David in 2 Sam. 17:10), the strategic uses of this word in Genesis 1-11 associate it with the sad portrait of human violence that violates God’s purposes for life. This violent strain runs from Cain to Nimrod.

Cain’s violence → Lemek’s escalated violence → the violent giants → Nimrod the violent warrior

“Men of the Name”

Genesis 6:4 says that fallen warriors of old used violent conquest in order to elevate their name. This is the narrator’s characterization of the human family in relation to the line and city of Cain.

In Genesis 6:4, we’re told that these warriors were not glorious founders of the ancient kingdoms and conduits of divine knowledge. Rather, they were the result of a spiritual rebellion and destined to “fall” unto death.

This portrait of a violent warrior (*Gibbor*) who achieves a great name through conquest is setting us up for the portrait of Nimrod in Genesis 10, the Babylonian desire for a great name in Genesis 11, and God’s desire to give Abram a name in Genesis 12.

- “Daughters of humanity” = human daughters
- “Sons of *Elohim*” = *elohim* beings, i.e., spiritual beings

This makes sense of why the text of Genesis 6:1 draws such a strong contrast between the “daughters of humanity” and the “sons of *Elohim*.” The point at issue is the violation of boundaries between human and divine.

Reflection Question

The author tells us that the Nephilim are “mighty warriors ... men of the name.” Is this a good thing or a bad thing? How do we know?